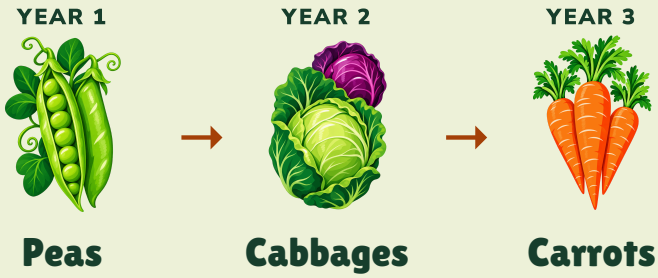
Crop rotation & planning

Rotation means moving plant families to different ground instead of planting the same or similar plants in the same place, year after year. Its most useful job in a small garden is to reduce the build-up of problems shared by related plants.

One bed, three different families

Peas, cabbages and carrots each belong to a different family. Rotation breaks pest cycles, and enhances nutrient take-up.



Keep a simple record

Sketch your beds and write down what grew where, including a second crop in the same year. Next season, move the main crop to ground that held an unrelated family. Changing cabbage for broccoli does not count: they share too many problems.

Let plants help each other

Follow peas and beans with leafy greens. Leave their nitrogen-rich roots in the soil to help feed the next crop. Add manure or compost before heavy eaters like potatoes and cucumbers; follow these with light feeders such as carrots.

Crop families: useful examples

Brassicas	Cabbage, kale, broccoli, Brussels sprouts, cauliflower, kohlrabi, radish, swede and turnip
Alliums	Onion, shallot, leek and garlic
Legumes	Peas and beans
Potato family	Potatoes, tomatoes, aubergines, peppers and chillies
Carrot family	Carrot, parsnip, celery, celeriac, Florence fennel, coriander and dill
Beet family	Beetroot, spinach and leaf beet (chard)
Cucumber family	Cucumber, courgette, marrow, pumpkin and squash
Lettuce family	Lettuce, chicory and endive

A rotation is not a disease cure

Clubroot and onion white rot, to take the two worst examples, can remain in soil for many years. A short circuit round the beds does not make infected ground clean. Keep contaminated soil off clean beds, and do not put infected allium debris into good compost.

John: Raised Beds and rotation notes. Crop and Troubles JSON; Garden Organic and University of Saskatchewan family tables.

Crop rotation & planning

One bed, two crops in the same year



Broad beans
Legumes

→



Kale
Brassicas

After early broad beans, use the bed for kale. Sow kale separately in June or early July; plant promptly when ready, often July or early August. Choose a suitable variety, allow time before winter and protect seedlings from pests. Record both families. See Kale, pages 40–41.

Four beds, four years

The acme of rotation is the traditional four-block rotation system, as seen in many an old gardening manual. It's prescriptive, but it gives you a clear plan for the whole plot. Divide the growing area into four beds or groups of beds, then move each crop group on one place each year.

Year	Bed A	Bed B	Bed C	Bed D
1	Peas & beans	Brassicas	Potatoes	Onions & roots
2	Brassicas	Potatoes	Onions & roots	Peas & beans
3	Potatoes	Onions & roots	Peas & beans	Brassicas
4	Onions & roots	Peas & beans	Brassicas	Potatoes

Read across a row to see the whole plot in one year; read down a column to follow one bed through time. In Year 5, the sequence returns to the Year 1 arrangement.

Put each crop in its group

Crop rotation groups are not always obvious. In the four-block system, radishes, swedes and turnips belong with the brassicas. Onions and other roots share a block even though they include different families.

Plan the changeover

Keep recording every crop, including a second crop in the same year. A bed may still be occupied when the new year starts. Make the changeover after harvesting, in time for the next crop's sowing or planting window.

Alternative strategy: A right British muddle

If you only have a small plot, or you have many different-sized beds, you can just mix plants up in small groups and let randomness and Nature do the rotation for you. It will still work; just keep things moving, and every year, do something different in each bed.

John: Raised Beds and rotation notes. Crop and Troubles records; RHS four-year rotation example.